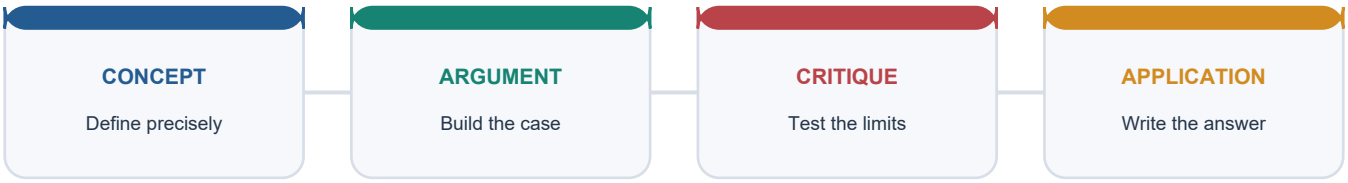
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

State & Government under Akbar (Mansabdari, Dahsala) - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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State & Government under Akbar (Mansabdari, Dahsala) - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 1

Question: Under Akbar, which statement most accurately defines a mansab?

A. It was a numerical imperial service rank linked to status, pay and obligation. B. It was a hereditary village office held by the patwari. C. It meant direct crown land kept under khalisa management. D. It referred only to branding cavalry horses.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This fits the core meaning. Mansab located a service-holder inside an imperial hierarchy and connected precedence with remuneration and expected service.
- **B:** This shifts the term to a village records office. Patwari work belonged to local revenue record-keeping, not to the all-India ranking system of nobles and officials.
- **C:** Khalisa described directly retained crown revenue, whereas mansab described rank. The option swaps a fiscal category for a service category.
- **D:** Horse branding belonged to **dagh**. Verification supported mansabdari, but it was not the definition of mansab itself.

Examiner trap: Students often collapse mansab, jagir and dagh into one blurred military term; the question separates rank from assignment and verification.

Workbook MCQ 2

Question: The clearest late-Akbar distinction between zat and sawar belongs to:

A. 1556, the accession year B. 1595-96, the fortieth regnal year C. 1565, when Muzaffar Khan Turbati rose D. the reign of Shah Jahan alone

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Accession-year administration was still shaped by regency politics. The mature dual formulation of zat and sawar should not be pushed back to 1556.
- **B:** This is the exam-safe chronology. The sharper separation of personal rank and cavalry obligation is associated with late Akbar, roughly 1595-96.
- **C:** 1565 matters for fiscal strengthening, not for the final crystallisation of the zat-sawar distinction.
- **D:** Shah Jahan is too late. Later Mughal refinements exist, but the dual distinction itself is already visible by late Akbar.

Examiner trap: When dates cluster closely, aspirants remember the concept but detach it from chronology; UPSC then uses the date as the real discriminator.

Workbook MCQ 3

Question: Which office under Akbar was most directly associated with presentation of mansabdars, muster and scrutiny of service claims?

A. Sadr-us-sudur B. Mir Saman C. Mir Bakhshi D. Diwan

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The sadr field handled grants and religious-judicial responsibilities. It did not run the empire's muster and ranking verification process.

- **B:** The mir saman dealt with the imperial household, karkhanas and supply organisation. That portfolio was material-administrative, not muster-centred.
- **C:** Correct. The mir bakhshi stood at the heart of mansab presentation, troop scrutiny and the practical testing of service obligations.
- **D:** The diwan was the finance and accounts pivot. Salary logic touched the diwan, but military verification itself did not belong to that office.

Examiner trap: Portfolio confusion between diwan and mir bakhshi is common because both touch remuneration, but only one tests service claims.

Workbook MCQ 4

Question: Which descending administrative order is correct for Akbar's empire?

A. Pargana - Sarkar - Suba - Village B. Sarkar - Pargana - Suba - Village C. Suba - Pargana - Sarkar - Village D. Suba - Sarkar - Pargana - Village

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This inverts the scale by placing the smaller pargana above the larger sarkar and province. The ladder becomes territorially impossible.
- **B:** Sarkar did sit above pargana, but both stood below suba. The option fails by placing the province too low.
- **C:** The opening term is right, yet the middle two units are reversed. Pargana was subordinate to sarkar, not superior to it.
- **D:** Correct. The provincial ladder runs from suba to sarkar to pargana and then to the village level.

Examiner trap: Many candidates know the three names but mis-sequence the middle pair under speed pressure.

Workbook MCQ 5

Question: What did dagh aim to check most directly?

A. Fraudulent or exaggerated cavalry claims through horse branding B. Corrupt grant distribution by the sadr office C. False measurement of cultivated fields by patwaris D. Incorrect copying of Persian chronicles

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Dagh branded horses so that a mansabdar could not too easily inflate mounted strength on paper.
- **B:** Grant control concerned the sadr sphere, not the specific inspection tool called dagh.
- **C:** Field measurement involved survey instruments and revenue personnel; dagh operated in the military-verification domain.
- **D:** Chronicles may shape evidence, but dagh belonged to practical inspection, not literary authentication.

Examiner trap: If one remembers dagh merely as "branding," the temptation is to forget what exactly was being branded and why.

Workbook MCQ 6

Question: In Mughal fiscal vocabulary, jama referred to:

A. actual collection already realised from the countryside B. assessed demand recorded on paper C. a category of uncultivated waste land D. horse rolls prepared under chehra

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Actual realisation was **hasil**. Choosing this option erases the vital paper-versus-practice distinction in Mughal finance.
- **B:** Correct. Jama meant the assessed revenue demand entered in records.
- **C:** Waste or uncultivated land relates to categories such as banjar, not to the accounting term jama.
- **D:** Descriptive rolls belong to military verification. Jama belongs to the fiscal ledger, not the muster register.

Examiner trap: UPSC often asks a single revenue word whose meaning seems familiar but quietly reverses jama and hasil.

Workbook MCQ 7

Question: Which statement about jagir under Akbar is the most accurate?

A. It granted hereditary private ownership over the soil. B. It was identical with village zamindari rights. C. It was a revenue assignment often used to meet salary obligations. D. It denoted the emperor's daily audience ritual.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Jagir did not convert state demand into unrestricted private landed property. The sovereign claim behind revenue remained imperial.
- **B:** Zamindari came from locally rooted intermediary power, while jagir came from imperial assignment. The two could intersect in practice but were conceptually different.
- **C:** Correct. Jagir functioned as assigned revenue that supported the remuneration chain of imperial service-holders.
- **D:** Daily audience belongs to jharoka darshan and public kingship, not to fiscal assignment.

Examiner trap: The question targets the old habit of translating jagir lazily as "feudal estate."

Workbook MCQ 8

Question: Which statement about the provincial diwan is most accurate?

A. He replaced the emperor as supreme judge of the empire. B. He served as chief cavalry commander in each province. C. He supervised only palace karkhanas and stores. D. He acted as a fiscal counterweight to the subadar within provincial administration.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Supreme justice remained ruler-centred and distributed through several judicial channels; the provincial diwan was not a substitute emperor.
- **B:** Cavalry verification belonged closer to the bakhshi sphere than to the diwanic fiscal chain.
- **C:** Karkhanas and stores belonged to the mir saman-buyutat world, not to the provincial diwan's main responsibility.
- **D:** Correct. The provincial diwan checked the governor by controlling accounts and revenue oversight.

Examiner trap: The examiner tests whether "important provincial officer" is translated into the right kind of importance-fiscal, not universal.

Workbook MCQ 9

Question: Which land category referred to regularly cultivated land in Akbar's revenue vocabulary?

A. Polaj B. Chachar C. Banjar D. Nasaq

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Polaj denoted land under regular cultivation and therefore formed the most stable base for assessment.
- **B:** Chachar referred to land left fallow for a longer period; it did not signify continuous current cultivation.
- **C:** Banjar described uncultivated or waste land, so it sits at the opposite end of the productive spectrum from polaj.
- **D:** Nasaq was a revenue method of rough estimation, not a land category at all.

Examiner trap: The trap works by mixing land classification terms with revenue methods and hoping the candidate recalls only Persian sound-patterns.

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: Which statement best captures the role of Muzaffar Khan Turbati, Todar Mal and Shah Mansur in Akbar's revenue history?

A. They were all village record-keepers outside central reform. B. They show that revenue reform was cumulative and team-based rather than the work of one official alone. C. They were famous chiefly for leading the imperial artillery. D. They abolished all local intermediaries in one stroke.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Local record expertise mattered, but these figures appear in the reform story at the higher administrative level, not as mere village scribes.
- **B:** Correct. Their combined presence breaks the myth of a one-man administrative miracle and shows a sequence of collective fiscal refinement.
- **C:** Artillery command is unrelated to why these names recur in Topic 16.
- **D:** No Mughal reform abolished local mediation wholesale; that claim overstates both state reach and administrative intention.

Examiner trap: Textbook memory often freezes on Todar Mal alone; UPSC can test whether the candidate knows the reform had collaborators and stages.

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: Which statement best distinguishes zabt from dahsala?

A. Zabt was crop-sharing, whereas dahsala was horse branding. B. Zabt meant village self-government, whereas dahsala meant provincial division. C. Zabt was the broader measured assessment framework, whereas dahsala was the ten-year averaging technique within it. D. Zabt applied only to mansab ranks, whereas dahsala applied only to jagirs.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Crop-sharing relates to batai and branding to dagh. Neither term captures the zabt-dahsala relationship.
- **B:** Both parts drift away from revenue assessment into unrelated administrative fields.
- **C:** Correct. Zabt provides the larger assessed framework and dahsala names the averaging procedure associated with it.
- **D:** Mansab and jagir are linked to service and remuneration, not to the specific definitional contrast between zabt and dahsala.

Examiner trap: Many learners memorise "zabt/dahsala" as a single lump and then fail when UPSC asks for internal differentiation.

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: Why does the jama-hasil distinction matter in Topic 16?

A. It shows the difference between court ritual and village custom. B. It proves that all revenue was collected in cash everywhere. C. It marks the divide between military rank and civilian office. D. It highlights the gap between assessed demand and actual realization.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Court ritual versus village custom belongs to another analytical line; jama-hasil is a fiscal contrast.
- **B:** If anything, the distinction warns that paper assessment did not automatically translate into easy realization, whether in cash or otherwise.
- **C:** Rank versus office concerns mansab and departmental portfolios, not jama-hasil.
- **D:** Correct. Jama is the assessment on record; hasil is what the state or assignee actually realizes.

Examiner trap: Some questions look like simple terminology but are actually asking whether the candidate understands implementation gaps.

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: Which statement best explains khalisa?

A. Revenue retained for direct imperial use B. Hereditary right of the zamindar C. A late-Mughal cavalry rank D. Crop estimate made by combining sight and measurement

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Khalisa denoted crown-managed revenue reserved for direct state expenditure.
- **B:** Zamindari described local intermediary claims and influence, not the directly retained fiscal category called khalisa.
- **C:** Cavalry rank belongs to sawar within mansabdari, not to khalisa.
- **D:** That description points toward kankut, a revenue method, not to khalisa territory.

Examiner trap: The item relies on candidates who recognise the word from jagir-khalisa pairings but never fixed the meaning of the second term.

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: Which statement best captures the place of zamindars in Akbar's agrarian order?

A. They were simply identical to tankhwah jagirdars. B. They were locally rooted intermediaries with social and coercive influence. C. They disappeared once zabt began. D. They existed only in areas kept under khalisa.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Jagirdars held imperial assignments; zamindars drew strength from local embedded authority. The two cannot be flattened into one category.
- **B:** Correct. Zamindars mattered as locally rooted intermediaries who helped shape collection, coercion and rural politics.
- **C:** Revenue rationalisation did not erase intermediary power. The state worked through local society rather than removing it entirely.
- **D:** Zamindari was not confined to khalisa tracts. It was a rural power form encountered across the agrarian landscape.

Examiner trap: The hidden test is whether the candidate understands "negotiated rule" at the village level, not merely central labels.

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: Which option correctly identifies a revenue method based on sharing the actual crop?

A. Dagh B. Dastur C. Batai or ghalla-bakhshi D. Chehra

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Dagh belongs to the verification of cavalry horses. It never meant division of harvest.
- **B:** Dastur refers to schedule or rate-setting logic inside revenue assessment, not to crop-sharing itself.
- **C:** Correct. Batai, also called ghalla-bakhshi, involved sharing the actual produce.
- **D:** Chehra was a descriptive roll of personnel, so this choice imports a military record into agrarian assessment.

Examiner trap: Administrative Persian terms are often scrambled across military and fiscal subfields; this item rewards conceptual sorting.

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: Which pairing is correctly matched?

A. Mir Saman - presentation of mansabdars B. Sadr-us-sudur - horse branding inspections C. Mir Bakhshi - household karkhanas and stores D. Mir Saman - imperial household and material supply

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Presentation of mansabdars fell under the mir bakhshi's field, not the mir saman's.
- **B:** The sadr dealt with grants and religious-judicial concerns; dagh inspections were outside that portfolio.
- **C:** Household stores and karkhanas were the mir saman's terrain. Assigning them to the mir bakhshi distorts both offices.
- **D:** Correct. The mir saman-buyutat sphere managed household provisioning and material organisation.

Examiner trap: Similar prestige-level offices tempt rote learners into random matching; only portfolio logic secures the answer.

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: Which statement about Akbar's kingship after the Bairam Khan phase is the most accurate?

A. The emperor reduced the risk of an over-mighty vakil while keeping authority ruler-centred. B. The emperor withdrew from direct appointments and left them to hereditary ministers. C. The vakil became more powerful than before and permanently overshadowed the throne. D. Jharoka darshan was abolished as incompatible with imperial visibility.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Akbar's response to the regency experience was to recentre authority on the throne while avoiding a second overwhelmingly powerful vakil.
- **B:** Appointments, transfer and justice remained tied to the emperor; they were not handed over to hereditary ministerial autonomy.
- **C:** This reverses the whole political lesson of the Bairam Khan episode.
- **D:** Jharoka reinforced visible kingship. It strengthened, rather than cancelled, ruler-centred authority.

Examiner trap: Political history and administrative history intersect here; forgetting the regency context produces the wrong institutional picture.

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: The term kankut in Mughal agrarian administration refers to:

A. a transfer-proof jagir right B. estimate by crop and measurement C. a grant made by the sadr D. a cavalry distinction added under Jahangir only

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Kankut was a revenue-assessment method, not a property right and certainly not a shield against transfer.
- **B:** Correct. Kankut worked through estimation that combined standing crop observation with measurement logic.
- **C:** Sadr grants belong to the religious-charitable field; kankut belongs to agrarian assessment.
- **D:** Later Mughal cavalry refinements concern a different vocabulary altogether and have no connection with kankut.

Examiner trap: The unfamiliar Persian term invites guessing; the safe route is to group it with revenue methods rather than offices or ranks.

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Jarib - cavalry branding device B. Ilahi gaz - graded mansab scale C. Bigha - measured area unit in land assessment D. Banjar - actual realization of revenue

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Jarib was a measuring rope or survey implement, not a military branding instrument.
- **B:** The Ilahi gaz was a standard of measurement, not a rank scale inside mansabdari.
- **C:** Correct. The bigha functioned as the area unit within the revenue-measurement framework.
- **D:** Banjar refers to uncultivated or waste land. Actual realization is hasil.

Examiner trap: The options deliberately pull technical land-measurement terms toward military or accounting meanings.

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Which statement best explains why alternative methods such as batai and nasaq continued under Akbar?

A. The empire never attempted any measured assessment at all. B. They survived only as ceremonial relics without fiscal use. C. They were needed because all provinces rejected cash commutation on principle. D. Regional conditions made a single universal method impractical.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Akbar very clearly pursued measurement and standardisation in suitable areas, so this option denies a major feature of the topic.
- **B:** These methods continued because they remained useful in practice, not because they were museum pieces.
- **C:** The problem was administrative suitability, record conditions and ecology, not some universal principled rejection of cash demand.
- **D:** Correct. Revenue plurality reflected adaptation to regional conditions where one formula would not work equally well.

Examiner trap: Students often misread plurality as proof of weakness; UPSC tests whether they can see flexibility as a form of capacity.

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: Which statement most accurately defines chehra?

A. It referred to descriptive rolls of personnel used in service verification. B. It meant the ten-year price average of dahsala. C. It was the direct-tax area retained under khalisa. D. It designated the village headman in Mughal records.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Chehra preserved descriptive details of personnel so that service claims could be checked more rigorously.
- **B:** Ten-year averaging belongs to dahsala, not to chehra.
- **C:** Khalisa is crown-managed revenue territory, which lies in a separate fiscal field.
- **D:** Village headmanship belongs to the muqaddam, not to chehra.

Examiner trap: Dagh and chehra are often memorised together; this item checks whether each term can be defined separately.

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: Which statement correctly captures the relation between mansab and jagir?

A. Mansab and jagir were identical expressions for the same institution. B. Mansab expressed rank, while jagir often supplied the assigned revenue through which remuneration could be met. C. Mansab referred only to cavalry and jagir only to infantry. D. Mansab denoted village custom and jagir denoted imperial ritual.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The two institutions were connected but not interchangeable. One ranked service; the other commonly financed it.

- **B:** Correct. This relation is central to Topic 16 because it ties hierarchy to fiscal support without collapsing the categories.
- **C:** The contrast between cavalry and infantry misses the actual administrative link between rank and assignment.
- **D:** Neither term belongs to the pair of village custom and court ritual proposed here.

Examiner trap: UPSC regularly exploits the tendency to use mansab-jagir as a fused slogan without internal clarity.

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: Which statement best explains the importance of jharoka darshan in Topic 16?

A. It replaced the need for provincial officials. B. It was Akbar's principal method of crop-sharing assessment. C. It formed part of visible ruler-centred kingship and access. D. It marked the conversion of jagirs into hereditary estates.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Public visibility could reinforce authority, but it did not make the administrative chain unnecessary.
- **B:** Jharoka belongs to political theatre and kingship, not to agrarian technique.
- **C:** Correct. It projected the emperor as a visible and accessible sovereign at the centre of rule.
- **D:** Hereditary estate logic has nothing to do with the audience practice signified by jharoka.

Examiner trap: The term looks cultural or religious, so some candidates ignore its administrative relevance to kingship and legitimacy.

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: Which statement best describes nasaq?

A. It was the office of the news writer in each province. B. It was a universal replacement for all other revenue methods after 1580. C. It denoted the emperor's personal salary from khalisa land. D. It referred to rougher or past-based estimation where detailed measurement was difficult.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** News-writing belongs to waqia-navis, not to nasaq.
- **B:** Nasaq was one among several methods; it did not wipe out zabt, batai or kankut.
- **C:** Khalisa revenue served state needs, but nasaq was not a personal salary label.
- **D:** Correct. Nasaq captured rougher estimation where finer measurement could not be carried out conveniently.

Examiner trap: By presenting nasaq next to universalistic language, the question checks whether the learner remembers Akbar's revenue plurality.

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: Which statement best expresses the character of Akbar's state?

A. It was centralised in design but negotiated in implementation. B. It was purely segmentary with no central ranking or fiscal structure. C. It was a theocratic order ruled entirely by the ulama. D. It rested only on urban ceremonial life without agrarian depth.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Mansabdari, jagir assignment, office differentiation and assessed revenue show central design, while zamindars, regional methods and realization gaps reveal negotiated practice.
- **B:** This erases the very institutions-mansab, diwanic control, provincial structuring-that give Akbar's state its marked central capacity.
- **C:** Religious authority remained politically relevant, yet Akbar's regime cannot be reduced to clerical rule.
- **D:** Agrarian revenue was the material base of imperial administration; the court did not float free from the countryside.

Examiner trap: Extremes are attractive in theory questions; the secure answer is usually a qualified formulation anchored in mechanisms.

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: Which statement about the diwan is most accurate?

A. He was the empire's chief translator of Persian chronicles. B. He handled revenue, accounts, expenditure and the fiscal side of jagir-khalisa management. C. He functioned mainly as the officer for branding and troop inspection. D. He supervised only mosque grants and learned endowments.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Literary translation is far outside the diwan's main portfolio in Topic 16.
- **B:** Correct. The diwan was central to accounts, revenue and expenditure, including the fiscal management that underlay jagir and khalisa distinctions.
- **C:** Branding and troop inspection belong to mir bakhshi-linked verification, not to the diwan.
- **D:** Grants and learned appointments align more with the sadr field than with the diwan.

Examiner trap: Because several offices touched money or favour, candidates often scatter functions without keeping the finance core intact.

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: Which statement about the 1580 reorganisation is correct?

A. It abolished provinces and replaced them with jagirs only. B. It introduced the fortieth-regnal-year zat-sawar formula. C. It is associated with the twelve-suba arrangement and a major revenue reorganisation. D. It transferred all fiscal authority permanently to village panchayats.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Jagirs financed service but did not replace the territorial structure of provincial administration.
- **B:** The explicit late zat-sawar distinction belongs to 1595-96, not to the 1580 moment.
- **C:** Correct. 1580 is a key year for both revenue restructuring and the twelve-suba arrangement.
- **D:** Panchayats remained important locally, yet nothing in 1580 amounted to handing all fiscal authority down to them.

Examiner trap: Several famous dates cluster in Akbar's reign; the question tests whether the student can attach the correct reform to the correct year.

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: Which option best states why jama could differ from hasil?

A. Because jama referred to military ranks while hasil referred to civil offices. B. Because jama counted only jagir land and hasil counted only khalisa land. C. Because jama measured village social status and hasil measured crop variety. D. Because paper assessment could exceed what was actually realized on the ground.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Both terms belong to fiscal accounting, not to a divide between military and civil personnel.
- **B:** Jagir and khalisa could each face realization problems; the distinction between jama and hasil is not confined to separate land pools in this way.
- **C:** Social status and crop variety are unrelated to the accounting gap signified here.
- **D:** Correct. The difference emerges because recorded demand and actual collection do not always coincide.

Examiner trap: The simplest definitions become analytical only when one remembers implementation gaps; this option tests that shift.

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: Which statement correctly identifies a village-level or near-village actor in Akbar's agrarian order?

A. Patwari as a local record-keeper B. Mir Bakhshi as the village headman C. Sadr as the cultivator's plough tax D. Waqia-navis as a hereditary zamindar title

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Patwaris were associated with village-level records and therefore with the everyday informational base of agrarian administration.
- **B:** Mir bakhshi was a high imperial office, not a village functionary.
- **C:** Sadr was an office, not a field tax category or peasant tool.
- **D:** Waqia-navis refers to a news writer, not to a hereditary landed designation.

Examiner trap: One reliable prelims strategy is scale detection-ask whether the term belongs to empire, province or village.

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: Which statement most accurately captures the role of Ain-i Akbari for Topic 16?

A. It is useless because court texts tell us nothing about administration. B. It is valuable mainly because it reveals norms, offices, schedules and imperial administrative self-description. C. It is the official answer key to all Mughal revenue disputes. D. It proves that provincial practice everywhere matched central intention perfectly.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Court texts are not useless; they are among the richest sources for administrative structure and ideology.
- **B:** Correct. Ain-i Akbari is especially useful for reconstructing offices, procedures and the record-minded spirit of Akbar's regime.
- **C:** No single source solves every dispute; historians still compare norm with practice and other evidence.
- **D:** The whole point of critical reading is to avoid assuming perfect implementation from a courtly normative text.

Examiner trap: Source questions reward balance-neither naive trust nor total dismissal of the Ain.

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: Why should Topic 16 avoid teaching the full jagirdari crisis in depth?

A. Because jagir itself was absent under Akbar B. Because Akbar banned all future changes in assignment practice C. Because the later crisis belongs mainly to a subsequent-topic chronological frame, though its seeds may be noted here D. Because jagirdari is purely a religious topic linked to Din-i Ilahi

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Jagir is central to Topic 16, so denying its presence destroys the whole remuneration chain.
- **B:** Assignment practice never froze history in place; later developments did occur.
- **C:** Correct. Topic 16 may note early tensions, but the full jagirdari crisis belongs to later Mughal history and should not swallow Akbar's own administrative frame.
- **D:** Jagirdari is a fiscal-administrative institution, not a religious doctrine.

Examiner trap: Deep study often tempts students to import later decline themes into earlier state-building answers; this item checks chronological discipline.

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: Which statement best explains why Akbar's administrative system is often called military-fiscal?

A. Because only soldiers paid land revenue and civilians were exempt. B. Because religious syncretism replaced the need for state finance. C. Because the empire ignored record-keeping and relied only on plunder. D. Because ranked service, revenue assessment and assignment of resources were tightly linked.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Revenue did not fall only on soldiers; the agrarian base remained central to the imperial economy.
- **B:** Religious policy and fiscal structure belong to different explanatory fields; one did not eliminate the other.
- **C:** Topic 16 shows the opposite: the regime invested heavily in records, categories and verification.
- **D:** Correct. Mansab, jagir, assessed revenue and service obligations were interlocked, which is why the phrase military-fiscal fits.

Examiner trap: The expression sounds theoretical, but UPSC expects the candidate to translate it into concrete links between rank, revenue and state power.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified/routed 2026 status for Topic 16

- No direct 2026 question was found for this owner after searching the mandated 2026 ledgers and paper repositories.
- `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\PYQ-INTEGRATION-AUDIT-2026.md` records **Medieval-Indian-History | Unique questions 0 | Route assignments 0 | Files updated 0** for the 2026 integration cycle.

PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims 2021 (direct route)

Paper route evidence: `_PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2018-2023.md` line 438 routes 2021 Q45 to Topic 16 as "Mughal administrative hierarchy paragana sarkar suba order." The OCR file `attempts\_pyq_text\QP-CSP-21-GeneralStudiesPaper-I-121021.pdf.txt` preserves the options.

Solved route: The correct ladder is **Suba -> Sarkar -> Pargana**, so the right printed option is the one containing that sequence.

Demand decoding: Sequence-identification on territorial hierarchy.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Fix province at the top, then discard every option that pushes pargana above sarkar.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: The route is exact to Session 5. Elimination works even if officers are forgotten.

How to improve/strengthen: Add village as the next rung and revise linked officers for each layer.

PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims 2019 (adjacent but high-yield)

Paper evidence: `attempts\_pyq_text\csp-p1.pdf.txt` preserves the stem on "difference/differences between Jagirdar and Zamindar" and statement fragments on land assignments and heredity.

Solved route: Jagirdar belongs to imperial revenue assignment; zamindar belongs to locally rooted intermediary authority. Any statement that equates jagir with ordinary hereditary ownership should be rejected.

Demand decoding: Concept differentiation between two rural power forms.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Keep assignment versus local rootedness clear. Then check whether the statement quietly reverses heredity or function.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: Though ledger-adjacent, it protects a central Topic 16 distinction tested repeatedly in both prelims and mains thinking.

How to improve/strengthen: Revise one memory line: jagir from above, zamindari from below.

PYQ 3 - UPSC Mains GS-I 2020, Q12 (adjacent source-method route)

Routing evidence: `_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md` line 156 records: *Persian literary sources of medieval India and the spirit of the age. Comment.*

Solved route: Persian sources like **Akbarnama** and **Ain-i Akbari** reveal imperial self-image, office structure, revenue vocabulary and the record-keeping spirit of Akbar's age, but they need critical reading because court texts amplify norm more readily than village reality.

Demand decoding: Source interpretation, not direct administrative narration.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Name the sources, show what they reveal, then qualify them as courtly and normative.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It converts source recall into method. Topic 16 benefits because Ain-style evidence underwrites many administrative claims.

How to improve/strengthen: Add the contrast between administrative norm and jama-hasil reality.

PYQ 4 - UPSC Mains GS-I 2025 (adjacent boundary practice)

OCR evidence: `attempts\_pyq_text\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 1.txt` preserves: *Examine the main aspects of Akbar's religious syncretism. (Answer in 150 words).* This sits in Topic 17, but it is retained here to train scope discipline.

Solved route: Use Ibadat Khana, sulh-i kul and Din-i Ilahi as anchors. Mention its political value for broad-based kingship, but keep administrative machinery outside the core answer.

Demand decoding: Boundary-control question on religious policy.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Define the syncretic thrust, name the principal expressions, close with limited social reach.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It helps Topic 16 precisely by teaching what not to over-teach in a state-and-government answer.

How to improve/strengthen: In Topic 16 answers, use this only as a brief kingship qualifier, not as a substitute for administration.

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks, 150 words

Question: Explain why mansabdari under Akbar should be described as a service-ranking system rather than a landed order.

Model answer: Mansabdari was a numerical service hierarchy linking rank, pay and obligation under the emperor. It gave precedence and remuneration, but did not by itself confer landed ownership. That distinction becomes clear when mansab is separated from jagir. The mansab described **place in service**; jagir often supplied the **revenue assignment** through which salary could be met. Because the emperor could appoint, promote and transfer mansabdars, the system integrated elites without converting rank into hereditary territorial power. The late distinction between **zat** and **sawar** sharpened this by distinguishing personal standing from cavalry obligation. Thus mansabdari bound ambition to imperial service rather than to autonomous landed lordship.

Demand decoding: Define and contrast.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Rank first, jagir second, transferability third.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It answers the phrase "rather than" through comparison rather than narration.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one line on combined civil-military deployment.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks, 150 words

Question: How did the pairing of subadar and provincial diwan act as a check within Akbar's provincial administration?

Model answer: The subadar exercised political and military authority in the province, but the provincial diwan retained the fiscal chain of accounts and revenue oversight. This prevented the governor from monopolising provincial resources. Since agrarian revenue financed the empire, Akbar could not leave the entire provincial machine in one pair of hands. The diwan's distinct responsibility allowed the centre to watch revenue realization, while other officers such as bakhshi and waqia-navis added further layers of oversight. The result was not modern separation of powers, but a practical imperial counterweight that reduced the danger of autonomous provincial consolidation.

Demand decoding: Focus on checking function, not officer list.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Name each office, show risk of concentration, explain the check.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It turns structure into mechanism.

How to improve/strengthen: Add sarkar-pargana consequences if more space is available.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks, 250 words

Question: "Calling Akbar's revenue system ‘Todar Mal's settlement' is useful but misleading." Discuss.

Model answer: The label remains useful because Todar Mal became the best-known face of Mughal revenue rationalisation. Yet it misleads if it implies that one man alone created a complete and final system. Akbar's revenue reform developed through experiment and adjustment. **Muzaffar Khan Turbati**, **Todar Mal**, **Shah Mansur** and local record-holders all contributed to the making of a more regular fiscal order. The regime moved through measurement drives, schedule problems, karori experiments and later refinements before the more recognisable **zabt-dahsala** phase took shape. Todar Mal remains important because he is closely associated with the better organised 1580 arrangement, but the strongest historical explanation is cumulative rather than heroic. The phrase is therefore useful as a mnemonic handle and misleading as a complete explanation.

Demand decoding: Write both sides of the quotation.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Begin with usefulness, then broaden to collaborators and stages, then conclude.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It provides balance and evidence instead of slogan.

How to improve/strengthen: Mention the continuing role of local qanungo knowledge.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks, 250 words

Question: Distinguish jagir from khalisa and explain why the distinction was central to Akbar's imperial finance.

Model answer: Khalisa was revenue kept under direct crown management, while jagir was revenue assigned to support a service-holder's salary claims. The distinction mattered because Akbar's state had to finance both its own central expenditure and its ranked service hierarchy. Khalisa supplied more directly disposable revenue, whereas jagir connected the agrarian base to the mansabdari structure without requiring all payments in immediate cash. The distinction also exposed administrative strain: paper **jama** could differ from actual **hasil**, and transferability, though useful against local entrenchment, could push assignees toward short-term extraction. Hence jagir and khalisa were not just fiscal labels; they were the two major channels through which imperial resources were organised and redistributed.

Demand decoding: Separate the two terms, then explain significance.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Define both, show central finance logic, then add the jama-hasil problem.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It connects terminology to the functioning of empire.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one line on sovereign claim over land remaining with the state.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks, 250 words

Question: Evaluate the significance and limits of zabt-dahsala in Akbar's agrarian administration.

Model answer: Zabt-dahsala was significant because it attempted to make agrarian demand more measurable, recordable and predictable. Through survey, land classification, schedules and ten-year averaging, the state could convert agrarian output into a more stable cash claim in suitable regions. This supported wider fiscal planning, more intelligible revenue records and better linkage between agrarian income and imperial finance. Yet the system was not universal. Areas with difficult ecology, unstable cultivation or weak records often required **batai**, **kankut** or **nasaq**. Moreover, the gap between **jama** and **hasil** meant that assessment on paper could outrun realization on the ground. Pressure on cultivators remained a live issue where commuted demand met bad harvests or local coercion. The true achievement of zabt-dahsala therefore lies in improved fiscal intelligibility, while its chief limits lie in uneven application and agrarian realities.

Demand decoding: Evaluate means achievement plus limitation.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Explain the technique, list gains, then mark the limits clearly.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It distinguishes design success from implementation success.

How to improve/strengthen: Explicitly state that dahsala is a technique within the wider zabt framework.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks, 250 words

Question: "Akbar created a centralised but negotiated state." Examine.

Model answer: Akbar's state was undeniably centralised in structure. The emperor controlled appointments and transfers; finance and service verification were differentiated through the **diwan** and **mir bakhshi**; the **mansabdari** system ranked elites in one imperial service order; and the territorial ladder from **suba** to **pargana** extended that order into provinces. Revenue administration reinforced this central design through measurement, classification, schedules and the jagir-khalisa chain of redistribution. Yet the same system was negotiated in practice. Provincial power needed internal checks, village realization depended on **zamindars, muqaddams and patwaris**, and multiple revenue methods survived because ecological and record conditions varied. Above all, **jama** could diverge from **hasil**, showing that recorded demand and lived realization were never identical. Akbar therefore built a strong military-fiscal monarchy, but not an omnipotent impersonal bureaucracy. Its power rested on ranking, assigning, assessing and supervising; its limits arose from local mediation, agrarian constraint and uneven implementation.

Demand decoding: Show both centralisation and negotiation before concluding.

Executable answer/elimination plan: One paragraph on structure, one on limits, one balanced verdict.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It handles the quotation directly and uses concrete institutions as evidence.

How to improve/strengthen: Add the Bairam Khan-vakil background if a sharper political opening is needed.